> heard such high praise, would sit down tamely and see themselves bearded at the very gates of their Cantonments by a few contemptible ill-assured savages.
>
> The eyes of the whole Afghan nation were now however opened. Every man was our enemy, and in lieu of the high character which we had hitherto borne, we were looked upon with the most utter contempt. The godown fort was this day something similar to a large ants' nest. By noon thousands & thousands had assembled from far & wide to participate in the booty of the English dogs, each man taking away with him as much as he could carry and to this we were all helpless eye witnesses.[52]

Afghan sources state that within twenty-four hours the rebels had taken three years' worth of military and food supplies, removing everything to within the city walls. 'They carried off the booty on their heads, and distributed thousands of maunds of grain among the Afghan villagers and nomads, so that, having eaten their fill, they too joined the revolt,' wrote Munshi Abdul Karim. 'Whatever was judged as too heavy to carry off, they destroyed.'[53]

Lady Sale was quite clear about the seriousness of what had happened: 'It gave both confidence and much plunder to the enemy and created great disgust among Europeans, who lost all their rum. A worse loss was all the medical supplies, sago, arrow root, wine &c, for the sick.'[54] Weeks later, when word of what had happened reached George Broadfoot in the besieged city of Jalalabad, he wrote an angry note in his diary:

> Colin Mackenzie was in the outskirts of the city in an old fort. For two days he fought, and then cut his way through to the large force, who did not seem able to cut their way through to him, bringing in all his men and the crowd of women and children safe, himself getting two sabre wounds. A more heroic action was never performed. The unhappy women and children have since perished or gone into slavery, because 5000 men could not do what he did with 50.[55]

Within the besieged cantonment, hunger soon began to set in.

The troops were put on half-rations, but as with the death march through the Bolan two years earlier, it was the camp followers and baggage animals who suffered first. 'Our cattle have been starving for some days past,' wrote Johnson in his diary a week later. 'Not a blade of grass nor a particle of bussorah [fodder] or grain is procurable for them.[bb] The barley in store is served out as rations to camp followers. They only get ¼ of a seer for their daily food. Our cattle are subsisting on the twigs, branches & bark of trees. Scarcely an animal is fit to carry a load.'[56] A week later the situation was even more dire: 'Our camp followers have for the past 2 days had nothing